



Easwaran. As the day progressed, they seemed bereft of many ideas other than the short ball.

Mohammed Siraj, returning from national team duty in Sri Lanka, lacked incision and looked short of rhythm in the heat, culminating in a nine-over spell on the final day with the game long gone.

Eyes to the future

Beyond the questions of immediate national team selections, several younger players also did enough to merit keeping an eye on them in the upcoming domestic season.

Shikhar Mohan, who finds himself in the Rest of India squad for the Irani Cup, scored twin fifties and bowled well, while Kumar Kushagra justified his inclusion in the upcoming India A squads for the Australia A series with a first-innings ton.

Md Kounain Qureshi, who made his First-Class debut in the semifinal, also produced an impressive

all-round performance, sending down nearly 40 overs of offspin before peeling off his maiden FC ton in the third innings.

There were also signs of further evolution in the wunderkind Sooryavanshi's red-ball game. With an adoring crowd watching on, the 15-year-old adopted a more circumspect attitude in his two stays at the crease, possibly providing a preamble to what could come for Bihar in the upcoming season.

A format change?

Perhaps the only disappointment was the lack of stakes imbibed in the action as the match came to a close.

East Zone's first-innings dominance with the bat gave it a near-impregnable position, and once it secured a first-innings lead on the fourth day, the remaining play became largely immaterial.

With an enthusiastic Chepauk crowd filling out the stadium for all five days, the final perhaps prompts

Playing the waiting game: Tilak Varma traded the rush of white-ball cricket for the patience of red-ball batting, grinding his way to a determined 99. THE HINDU

a gentle discussion about whether a different tiebreaker can be used going forward. But final-day drudgery aside, the Duleep Trophy 2026 final served as just the right sampler for what promises to be a competitive domestic season.



Brief scores

East Zone 708 (Kishan 270, Kushagra 101, Vijay 4-180) and 388 for 7d (Quraishi 116*, Kishan 80, Nidheesh 2-28) drew with **South Zone 336** (Tilak 99, Padikkal 62, Mukesh 3-62, Shami 2-42). *East won on first-innings lead.*